

Troubleshooting guide for sudden inter-cat aggression — Action Checklist

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RULE OUT MEDICAL CAUSES FIRST

- ☐ **Complete the 15-item Pain and Illness Checklist for both cats today, rating every item as Yes, No, or Unsure and photographing the results with the date to establish a medical baseline for your veterinarian.:** Complete the 15-item Pain and Illness Checklist for both cats today, rating every item as Yes, No, or Unsure and photographing the results with the date to establish a medical baseline for your veterinarian.
- ☐ **Schedule a veterinary appointment immediately if any checklist item registers as Yes or Unsure, because sudden aggression in previously stable cats requires medical evaluation before any behavioral intervention can be effective.:** Schedule a veterinary appointment immediately if any checklist item registers as Yes or Unsure, because sudden aggression in previously stable cats requires medical evaluation before any behavioral intervention can be effective.
- ☐ **Observe whether one cat consistently flinches, freezes, or moves away when the other approaches even casually, which may indicate the aggressor is experiencing pain that makes normal interactions unbearable.:** Observe whether one cat consistently flinches, freezes, or moves away when the other approaches even casually, which may indicate the aggressor is experiencing pain that makes normal interactions unbearable.
- ☐ **Note any recent medication changes, supplements, or flea treatments started in the last 30 days for either cat, as new medications can cause behavioral side effects including unexplained aggression toward companions.:** Note any recent medication changes, supplements, or flea treatments started in the last 30 days for either cat, as new medications can cause behavioral side effects including unexplained aggression toward companions.

IDENTIFY ENVIRONMENTAL TRIGGERS

- ☐ **Conduct a room-by-room assessment for environmental changes such as new furniture, rearranged spaces, unfamiliar scents from visitors, or construction noise that may have disrupted your cats' established territory.:** Conduct a room-by-room assessment for environmental changes such as new furniture, rearranged spaces, unfamiliar scents from visitors, or construction noise that may have disrupted your cats' established territory.

- **Evaluate resource distribution throughout your home by checking whether food bowls, water stations, litter boxes, and resting spots are adequate in number and strategically placed to prevent competition between your cats.:** Evaluate resource distribution throughout your home by checking whether food bowls, water stations, litter boxes, and resting spots are adequate in number and strategically placed to prevent competition between your cats.

- **Watch for signs of redirected aggression by identifying any triggers your cats cannot directly access, such as outdoor cats visible through windows, loud construction sounds, or new pets in neighboring apartments.:** Watch for signs of redirected aggression by identifying any triggers your cats cannot directly access, such as outdoor cats visible through windows, loud construction sounds, or new pets in neighboring apartments.

- **Begin a scent exchange protocol by rubbing clean socks on each cat's face and cheeks and placing them in the other cat's space, allowing them to investigate the exchanged scent without direct confrontation.:** Begin a scent exchange protocol by rubbing clean socks on each cat's face and cheeks and placing them in the other cat's space, allowing them to investigate the exchanged scent without direct confrontation.

EXECUTE SAFE REINTRODUCTION

- **Establish a complete separation protocol keeping both cats in entirely distinct areas with closed doors between them for a minimum of 48 hours, ensuring no visual or physical contact during this cooling-down period.:** Establish a complete separation protocol keeping both cats in entirely distinct areas with closed doors between them for a minimum of 48 hours, ensuring no visual or physical contact during this cooling-down period.

 - **Progress to supervised visual contact through a barrier such as a baby gate while feeding both cats their favorite treats, rewarding calm behavior and separating immediately at the first sign of tension or stalking.:** Progress to supervised visual contact through a barrier such as a baby gate while feeding both cats their favorite treats, rewarding calm behavior and separating immediately at the first sign of tension or stalking.

 - **Maintain separate food bowls, litter boxes, water stations, and resting areas throughout the entire reintroduction process, keeping all resources in their designated separated spaces to prevent resource-guarding conflicts.:** Maintain separate food bowls, litter boxes, water stations, and resting areas throughout the entire reintroduction process, keeping all resources in their designated separated spaces to prevent resource-guarding conflicts.
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- **Check the Full Guide:** This step is described in detail in the companion guide — open `cat-sudden-aggression-reintroduction-guide.md` and review the relevant section.

Companion to the full guide in your Lemon Squeezy library — check off each item as you complete it.